



The Double Life of Véronique

La Double Vie de Véronique

Director: Krzysztof Kieslowski

Production Company: Sidéral

In association with: Canal+,

Zespół Filmowy "Tor", Norsk Film

Executive Producer: Bernard P. Guiremand

Executive Producer (Poland): Ryszard Chutkowski

Producer: Leonardo De La Fuente

Co-producer: Ryszard Straszewski

Production Manager: Daniel Szuster

Production Assistants: Gérard Monier,

Christine Gaymay, Brigitte Chaussade,

Thibault Leflaive, Laurent Salotti,

Pierre-Yves Ferrandis, Włodzimierz Dziatkiewicz

Casting: Margot Capelier, Caroline Castelain

Casting (France): Catherine Maloubier

Screenplay: Krzysztof Kieslowski,

Krzysztof Piesiewicz

Polish Dialogue Adaptation: Martin Latalo

Director of Photography: Sławomir Idziak

Puppets: Bruce Schwartz

Editor: Jacques Witta

Production Designers: Patrice Mercier,

Halina Dobrowolska

Art Director: Krzysztof Zanussi

Costumes: Laurence Brignon, Claudy Fellous,

Elżbieta Radke

Make-up: Agnès Tassel, Iwona Skwarka,

Jolanta Stachecka

Music: Zbigniew Preisner

Music Performed by:

Polish Radio and Television Symphony Orchestra,

Philharmonic Choir of Silesie

Music Performer (Soprano): Elżbieta Towarnicka

Music Performer (Flute): Jacek Ostaszewski

Music Director: Antoni Wit

Sound Recording: William Flageollet,

Jean-Pierre Lelong, Mario Melchiori, Jack Jullian

Sound Re-recording: Patrice Séverac

Sound Editors: Edith Vassard, Michele Catonné

Production Advisers: Greta Lahaje,

Alejandro De La Fuente, Elizabeth De La Fuente,

Ruben Korenfeld, Raymond Parizer

Collaborators: Maciej Wojtulewicz, Józef Tutaj,

Euzebia Rubaszewska, Ewa Sikora, Jolanta Stec,

Elżbieta Słupisńska, Anna Ignatiuk,

Agnieszka Skawisńska

Cast:

Irène Jacob (*Weronika/Véronique*)

Halina Gryglaszewska (*Aunt*)

Kalina Jedrusik (*gaudy woman*)

Aleksander Bardini (*orchestra conductor*)

Władysław Kowalski (*Weronika's father*)

Jerzy Gudejko (*Antek*)

Jan Sternisński (*lawyer*)

Philippe Volter (*Alexandre Fabbri*)

Sandrine Dumas (*Catherine*)

Louis Ducreux (*teacher*)

Claude Duneton (*Véronique's father*)

Lorraine Evanoff (*Claude*)

Guillaume de Tonquédec (*Serge*)

Gilles Gaston-Dreyfus (*Jean-Pierre*)

Alain Frerot (*postman*)

Youssef Hamid (*railwayman*)

Thierry de Carbonnières (*professor*)

Chantal Neuwirth (*receptionist*)

Nausicaa Rampony (*Nicole*)

Bogusława Schubert (*woman with hat*)

Jacques Potin (*man in grey coat*)

Nicole Pinaud

Philippe Campos

Beata Malczewska

No Strings Attached: Puppets on Film

The Double Life of Véronique

With its obsessive brooding on objects – their unearthly light, their depths of emotive resonance, their portentous presence – it would be fair to say that *The Double Life of Véronique* is concerned with the luminous, the numinous and the ominous. Foremost in the film's system of objects is the mirror, as befits a story about duality and specularity. Mirrors are everywhere, splitting up the screen, reflecting and refracting gazes, multiplying space: the mirror in which Véronique first sees her lover, the mirror manipulated by a child across the street to throw a strange light into her room, and finally the dual image of Véronique embracing her father. But the film's multiplication of space, time and identity is sufficiently indeterminate to open up the narrative far beyond a clear-cut dualism. Even the *doppelgänger* premise alluded to in the title is ambivalent. The story may be about one woman with a double life, about two women with one life between them, or about two entirely separate lives. Not only are events and characters doubled, but so is the narrative itself. The tape Véronique receives, apparently a recording of earlier events, is also a pre-recording, a prediction of things she will witness in Paris. Her meeting with Alexandre will inspire him to write a story called 'The Double Life of...' but that is already (partly) the title of the fiction in which she is a character – a fiction already written by him, at least insofar as he has scripted his manipulation of her.

Seen in this light, the film might seem a fairly conventional box of ontological tricks, recycling traditional meta-fictional paradoxes. But it offers enough texture and energy to escape the formalist bounds it ostensibly sets itself. Irène Jacob's performance is crucial in this respect, for it completely resists her integration into the film as a mere cipher; this is all the more impressive since her part is essentially a function, duality personified. In the first close-up of Weronika, a choir disperses around her and she remains stock still, relishing a sudden downpour and holding on to one last long note. Weronika, we see here, is isolated within the world yet ready to react to it intensely. The two Veronikas seem to be the toys of chance, yet it is their child-like responsiveness to the moment that makes chance. But what, or who, really determines the lives of the Veronikas? Although they appear to be in control, they don't so much make decisions as follow the obscure promptings of fate, or of something that the film implies to be innate female insight (as exemplified by the tarot-reading aunt). They seem to make their own amorous decisions, yet Véronique falls for a puppeteer who aspires to manipulate her, to turn her into one of his somewhat precious figurines. The Veronikas certainly inhabit a male world, without mothers and with an overabundance of fathers (real fathers, as well as surrogate ones in the form of singing teachers).

This circle is broken, however, by a fundamental reconciliation. The whole film works towards that moment when Véronique will recognise herself in the Krakow photo and finally reciprocate the searching gaze of Weronika. It is only this reciprocity of female looks that salvages the film from the suspicion that Weronika/Véronique is entirely an object of male construction. Véronique's reconciliation is also, finally, with the world from which she had been isolated. Both women occupy their own hermetic realm, tending to see the world through their inverting globe, or moving at odds to it. In a pivotal scene, Weronika walks through a political demonstration, oblivious to all but her own mirror image. This is one of only two explicitly political moments, the other

Dominika Szady
Barbara Szalapa
Jacek Wojcicki
Lucyna Zabawa
Wanda Kruszezewska
Bernadetta Kus
Pauline Monier
Anna Gronostaj (*Polish voice of Weronika*)*
France-Poland-Norway 1991
98 mins
Digital

* Uncredited

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being an early shot of a huge statue being towed away (a father figure cut down? an end of monolithic Communism, giving way to Weronika's solipsistic individualism?). That the film otherwise seems so pervasively apolitical must frustrate anyone interested in Kieslowski's motives for working in the East and the West in the same film.

East and West finally seem to form merely another of the mirrorings that structure the film. Véronique comes across as a European art film, cerebral as well as sensual, and using the stylistic devices characteristic of a Resnais. The analytical realism of the *Decalogue*, with its grey panoramas and sense of a harsh encroaching world, is replaced with close-ups, shots through globes, and a sometimes stifling golden glow of amniotic well-being, as if the Veronikas' lives were enclosed in a protective bubble that can only be shattered by the viewer's eye. It is hard to decide what we're seeing here – a hermetic narrative game, a moral parable about the dangers of solipsism, or simply a confused inquiry into the Mystery of Woman. But the film's teasing paradoxes make for a complexity that is considerably more than double.

Jonathan Romney, *Sight and Sound*, March 1992

The Double Life of Véronique, as the UK distributor has re-titled Kieslowski's film – presumably in the belief that a French 'Véronique' is worth two Polish 'Weronikas' in the British market – opens up a new perspective on the director's career. It is his first co-production and his first fiction set largely outside Poland. It starts from a 'fantastic' premise: that if many people in the world are fundamentally very similar, why shouldn't there be two who are, in fact, identical?

Kieslowski and his now regular co-writer Krzysztof Piesiewicz imagine two girls, one Polish, one French, born on the same day in 1966 with the same glorious singing voice and the same potentially fatal heart condition. Whatever metaphysical, moral or auteurist complications anyone may discover in this schema, one thing is clear: the film is the most sophisticated approach to co-production yet. It takes the constraints that have scuttled countless earlier movies (the need to balance different national interests, languages and cultures) and makes them the foundation of the fiction itself.

Kieslowski has admitted that the project was just as much an aleatory one for him as it is for its audience. The film, he says, went through 20 alternative cuts before it reached its present form, and he shot seven possible endings, none of which (including the present one) struck him as being fully adequate. This bears out what he wrote in his introduction to the English edition of the *Decalogue* scripts: 'We know no more than you. But maybe it is worth investigating the unknown, if only because the very feeling of not knowing is a painful one.' Perhaps this is the key to understanding the importance Kieslowski has assumed in European cinema. Unlike most of his contemporaries – the ageing radicals, the angry social critics, the directors of freshened-up melodramas, the formalists, the unreconstructed hippie dreamers – he approaches his subjects in a spirit of sincere enquiry, allowing content to shape form and the concrete circumstances surrounding the production to define the parameters of the work.

Tony Rayns, *Sight and Sound*, March 1992